In contrast, the path of the Southern Road has drifted over time although certain nodes remained important over long periods. During the early Iron Age, the Dakshina Path probably began near Allahabad where two navigable rivers, the Ganga and Yamuna, flowed into each other. It then went in a south-westerly direction through Chitrakoot and Panchavati (near Nashik) and eventually to Kishkindha (near Hampi, modern Karnataka). This would be the route followed by Rama during his exile.

The Ramayana is traditionally said to be the older of the two texts, although some scholars dispute this. There are several versions of the epic, including versions that remain popular in other parts of Asia. The most prestigious and possibly oldest version, however, is the one composed in Sanskrit by the sage Valmiki. He was a former brigand as well as an outcaste—someone we would today call a Harijan or Dalit (that is, a member of the lowest castes). It is interesting that this early example of Dalit literature would come to occupy such an important place in later orthodoxy.

Despite many differences, the various versions of the Ramayana do agree on the basic storyline: Rama is the young and popular crown prince of Ayodhya (now a small town in the state of Uttar Pradesh). However, he is forced to give up his claim to the throne and is exiled for fourteen years. Along with his wife Sita and younger brother Lakshman, Rama heads south, crosses the river Ganga near modern-day Allahabad and goes to live in the forests of Central India. After several years of living peacefully in the forest, Sita is abducted by Ravana, the powerful king of Lanka. Rama and his brother set out to find her. On the way, at a place called Kishkindha, they befriend a tribe of monkeys that promises to help them. Hanuman, the strongest of the monkeys, visits Lanka and discovers that Sita is being held captive in Ravana’s palace garden. Together with the army of monkeys, Rama marches on Lanka but finds that the sea bars the way. So Rama and the monkeys build a bridge (more accurately a causeway) from Rameswaram to Lanka. A great battle ensues in which Ravana is defeated and killed, and Sita is rescued. Rama, Sita and Lakshman then return to Ayodhya and Rama regains his throne. Most versions of the story end here